WHAT IS SPARC?

Imagine that two people receive the same cancer diagnosis. They may have similar symptoms, but their cancers can behave very differently and respond differently to treatment.

How can doctors better understand these differences? How can they choose the right treatment for the right patient at the right time?

These are some of the questions that SPARC is trying to address.

SPARC Project is a European project that brings together patients, clinicians, researchers, policymakers, and innovators to help make personalised cancer care a reality across Europe.



What is Personalised Medicine?

Personalised medicine means understanding each person's cancer and overall health in depth, to support more informed and tailored treatment decisions.



Personalised medicine means moving away from a "one-size-fits-all" approach. Instead, it uses information about a person's cancer, health condition, and treatment history to support more tailored decisions.

But innovation alone is not enough. New tests and treatments can only benefit patients if they are accessible, understandable, trusted, and integrated into everyday healthcare. This is why SPARC focuses not only on science and technology, but also on implementation, education, policy, and patient involvement.

Co-funded by the European Union

Sparc

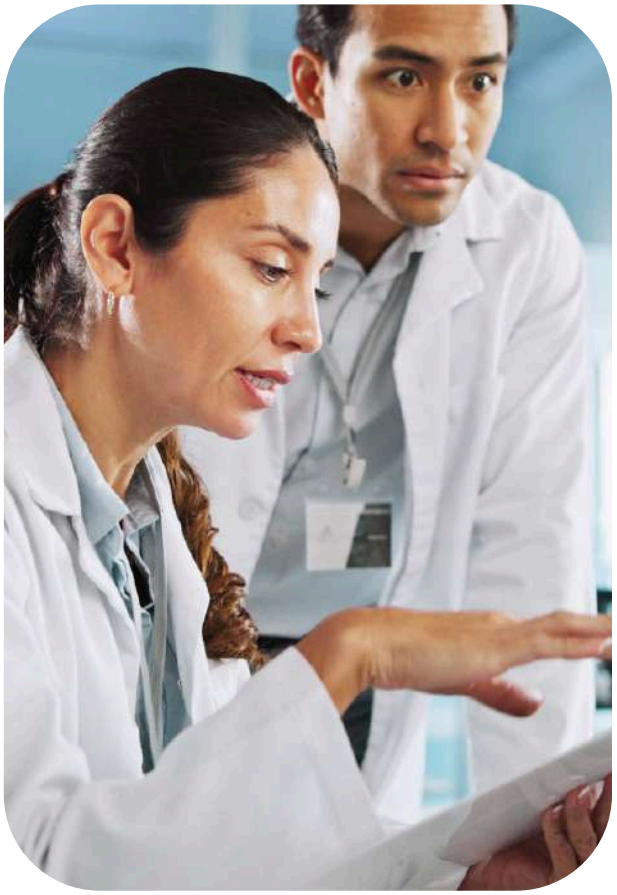
HOW DOES SPARC WORK?

To understand what works in real clinical practice, **SPARC is developing seven pilot projects** covering different cancer types and healthcare challenges.

These pilots explore how personalised medicine approaches can support patients across different stages of the cancer journey, from diagnosis and treatment selection to monitoring and follow-up care.

By studying real-world examples, SPARC aims to identify barriers, share good practices, and develop recommendations that can help improve cancer care across Europe.

These seven pilots help SPARC understand what works, what challenges still exist, and how personalised cancer can be successfully integrated into everyday healthcare.



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WHY ARE PATIENTS INVOLVED?

Because no one understands the cancer journey better than patients and their families. Patients help SPARC understand:

- Which needs are still not being met.
- What information is important when making treatment decisions.
- What barriers exist when accessing innovative care.
- How healthcare systems can become more patient-centred.

Patient experiences are therefore not simply collected: they actively help shape the project's discussions, priorities, and recommendations.



WHAT IS THE ULTIMATE GOAL?



A future where every person affected by cancer can benefit from the advances of personalised medicine- regardless of where they live, which hospital they attend, or how complex their cancer may be. A future where innovation is not only developed, but successfully reaches the patients who need it.

HOW DOES A EUROPEAN PROJECT LIKE SPARC WORK?

European projects like SPARC are created to help people from different countries work together on shared healthcare challenges. They bring together hospitals, researchers, patient organisations, healthcare professionals, policymakers, and other experts to exchange knowledge and improve care for patients across Europe.

SPARC includes partners from several European countries, each contributing a different perspective and expertise:

- Doctors & Researchers: Help understand scientific and clinical challenges
- Patients & Patient Advocates: Bring real-life experiences and priorities
- Policymakers & Healthcare Experts: Explore how innovations can realistically reach healthcare systems
- Communication & Engagement Teams: Help ensure discussions remain understandable & inclusive.

To organise such a large collaboration, the project is divided into smaller thematic groups called "**Work Packages**" (often shortened to "WPs").

Sparc includes 9 Work Packages, each focusing on a specific area, from scientific and clinical activities to education, training, and patient and stakeholder engagement.

Project partners meet regularly during consortium meetings, where they share updates, discuss progress, exchange ideas, identify challenges, and plan the next steps. These meetings also provide an important opportunity to hear different perspectives, including those of patients, helping ensure the project remains connected to real experiences and needs.



SPARC AND EUROPE'S CANCER POLICY EFFORTS

SPARC works closely with the European Joint Action on Personalised Cancer Medicine (JA PCM).

A Joint Action is a large European collaboration that helps countries work together on healthcare priorities. JA PCM specifically supports European countries in improving how personalised cancer care is introduced and used in real healthcare systems.

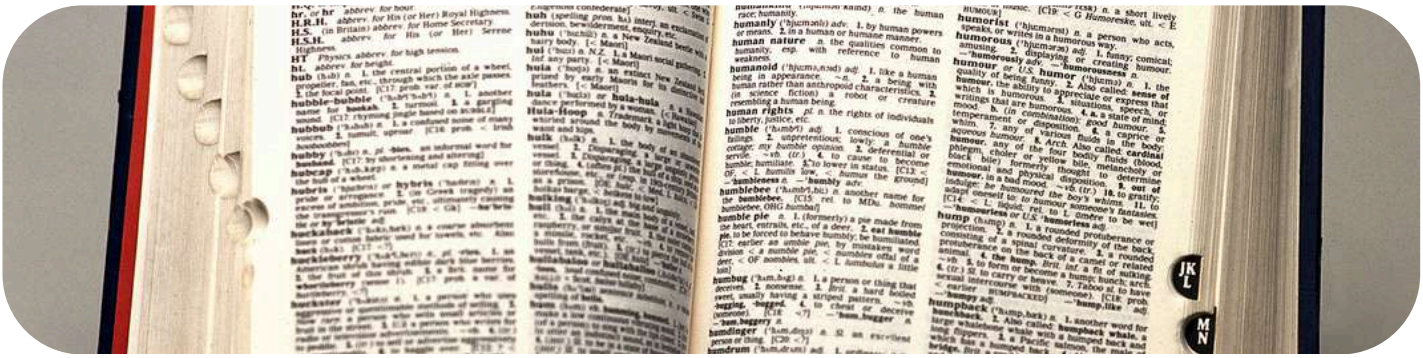
One way to imagine the relationship between the two initiatives is to think of SPARC as the smaller and more agile “companion project” to JA PCM. SPARC works on a smaller and faster scale, which allows to explore concrete ideas, test approaches in practice through pilot activities, gather feedback from patients and professionals, and identify challenges more quickly. In this way, SPARC can generate practical experiences and real-world insights that may also help inform the broader discussions and activities taking place within JA PCM.

Together, the two initiatives aim to support a future where personalised cancer care becomes more accessible, understandable, and useful for patients across Europe.



JA PCM Kick-Off Meeting (Brussels, January 2026)

USEFUL WORDS AND ACRONYMS USED IN SPARC



Projects like SPARC often use many technical words and abbreviations.

This can sometimes make discussions feel difficult to follow, especially because healthcare, research, and policy communities often use “short names” for complex concepts.
The goal is not for patients to become technical experts, but to help everyone feel more comfortable participating in discussions and asking questions.

Here are a few important terms you may hear during the meeting:

- **NGS: Next Generation Sequencing**

NGS is a laboratory method used to analyse cancer cells in great detail by looking at their genetic information (sometimes called “DNA changes” or “mutations”). In simple terms, it helps doctors better understand the specific characteristics of a tumour and may support more personalised treatment decisions.

- **LB: Liquid Biopsy**

A liquid biopsy is a test usually performed on a blood sample. Instead of taking a tissue sample directly from the tumour, doctors look for tiny traces of cancer-related material circulating in the blood. This may help monitor how a cancer changes over time or how it responds to treatment. Because it is less invasive than some traditional procedures, liquid biopsy is an area of strong interest in personalised cancer care research.

- **MTB: Molecular Tumour Board**

A Molecular Tumour Board is a group of specialists who discuss complex cancer cases together.
These discussions can involve oncologists, pathologists, genetic experts, laboratory specialists, and other healthcare professionals. The goal is to review different types of medical and molecular information together & explore which treatment options may be most relevant for a specific patient.